Book Review

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Forests of Refuge: Decolonizing Environmental Governance in the Amazonian Guiana Shield

One of the first things that struck me about Yolanda Ariadne Collins' book is its evocative title, which beautifully encapsulates the essence of her work, intertwining environmental focus with the critical need for decolonising governance. 'Forests' signify the rich biodiversity and the critical ecological zones that are at the heart of this study, while 'Refuge' speaks to the idea of these forests as sanctuaries not only for wildlife but also for the communities that have historically protected them. The notion of 'Decolonizing Environmental Governance' is a powerful call to action, urging readers to rethink and reconstruct the frameworks that dictate conservation and environmental policies. The book is thus a robust and thought-provoking examination of the intersections between colonial histories, environmental governance, and contemporary challenges in the Guiana Shield.

This work stands out not only for its rich historical analysis, but also for its critical insights into the lingering impacts of colonialism on environmental policies and practices. From my own experiences in decolonising scientific collaborations, Collins' arguments regarding the need for equitable partnerships resonate strongly. In many international projects, persistent 'equity washing' mirrors the superficial efforts of environmental governance that are the subject of Collins' critiques. This superficiality often leads to tokenism rather than meaningful change, a point vividly illustrated by Collins' exploration of the shortcomings of the Reducing Emissions from Deforestation and Forest Degradation (REDD+) programme.

Collins aims to examine and break down the colonial influences that are still present in today's environmental governance systems. She explores how these legacies continue to shape and sometimes prevent effective conservation efforts, particularly those involving the REDD+ programme. The author successfully makes the case that a complete decolonisation of environmental governance requires a thorough reconsideration of both past and present power structures.

The book is meticulously structured, beginning with an introduction that sets the stage for detailed analyses in subsequent chapters. Collins introduces the reader to the Guiana Shield, a region spanning parts of Guyana, Suriname, and French Guiana, rich in biodiversity but fraught with historical and ongoing exploitation. The introduction is essential for readers unfamiliar with the region, providing the necessary context for subsequent discussions.

Collins' approach aligns with best practices in decolonising science, such as avoiding tokenism and fostering long-term trust-based collaborations. In my work, I have found that projects that fail to build genuine, sustained partnerships often replicate the very inequalities they seek to address. Each chapter delves into different facets of environmental governance and its colonial underpinnings. Chapter 1, "Between a Mine and a Hard Place", examines the impact of gold mining on local communities and ecosystems. Collins highlights the environmental degradation caused by mining and the socioeconomic challenges faced by displaced communities such as the Maroons in Brownsweg, Suriname. She vividly describes, "The experience of being forced from their lands brought about loss of human life in the communities... these relocated maroons now engage in gold mining as their major source of income" (69). This is a stark reminder of the need for such 'refuge'—both in the literal and metaphorical sense. This alignment of the book's content with its title reinforces the depth and thoughtfulness of Collins' analysis, making the title not just a label, but a lens through which to view the entire narrative. This chapter also sets a critical tone for the book, emphasising the often-overlooked human dimension of environmental policies.

In Chapter 2, "Behead the Sovereign", Collins argues for reducing the centrality of sovereign state governance in managing forests. She posits that state-centric approaches rooted in colonial governance structures are ill-equipped to address the needs and rights of the local communities. This chapter is particularly original in its call to "decenter" markets and state authority, advocating instead for governance models that are more inclusive of Indigenous and local perspectives. The emphasis on inclusive governance models reflects my advocacy for co-designing research projects with local partners. Ensuring that all voices are heard and respected is not just ideal, but essential for sustainable and just outcomes.

Chapter 3, "Decenter Markets", critiques the neoliberal approach to environmental conservation, in which market mechanisms are often viewed as the primary solution to environmental problems. Collins illustrates how these market-based strategies, including REDD+, often fail to account for the complex sociocultural and historical contexts of the regions they aim to protect. This critique is both timely and relevant, and resonates with ongoing debates about the efficacy and ethics of market-driven conservation efforts.

Chapter 4, "Undiscipline the Subjects", discusses the process of forming, disciplining, and undisciplining subjects, particularly in the context of REDD+ governance. It examines

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how the market-based governance approach fails to consider the fragmented and historically conditioned subjectivities of local communities. The chapter emphasises the need to recognise and address historical injustices that shape current behaviours, advocating for alternative ways of being that challenge colonial and market-driven norms. Chapter 5, "Counter Discipline with Truths", explores how Indigenous and local communities resist the market-driven discipline imposed by REDD+ initiatives. It highlights the importance of recognising the cultural and spiritual connections these communities have with their land. The chapter argues that true decolonisation involves validating these historically marginalised truths, which can fundamentally challenge current land governance and potentially return significant control to Indigenous populations.

One of the strengths of this book is its interdisciplinary approach, which draws on history, anthropology, political science, and environmental studies to provide a comprehensive analysis. Collins' participant observation and extensive fieldwork in Guyana and Suriname lend authenticity and depth to her heartfelt arguments. Her engagement with local communities and reflections on their lived experiences enrich the narrative, making it both informative and engaging.

While Collins' critique of REDD+ and other market-based conservation strategies is compelling, I missed, occasionally, clearer articulation of viable alternatives. The call to "undiscipline the subjects", as discussed in Chapter 4 (115), while intellectually stimulating, leaves readers with questions about practical implementation. How can policymakers effectively transition from entrenched colonial frameworks to more inclusive and decolonised models of governance? This is an area in which the book, and all of us, could benefit from more concrete examples and actionable recommendations. In my experience, successful decolonisation efforts require critical analysis, but also practical guidelines for implementation. Concrete examples and actionable steps are thus essential for translating theoretical insights into real-world change.

In terms of style, Collins writes with clarity and passion, although the academic tone might be challenging for general readers. The production quality of the book is also commendable, with well-organised chapters that facilitate easy navigation through complex topics, although some readers might find dense theoretical content demanding. I would have loved to have even more photographs to guide me through the text. Nevertheless, for scholars, policymakers, and activists interested in environmental justice, postcolonial studies, and sustainable development, *Forests of Refuge* is an invaluable resource. Collins' work fills a significant gap in the current understanding of environmental governance in postcolonial contexts that lies in the failure to address the historical and ongoing impacts of colonialism on local communities and their environment. Her critique of REDD+ and other market-based conservation strategies, which often ignore the complex sociocultural and historical contexts of the regions they aim to protect, is compelling and relevant, particularly considering ongoing debates about the role of neoliberalism in environmental policy. By integrating decolonial perspectives, Collins provides a more comprehensive approach to environmental governance that recognises and addresses the legacies of colonial exploitation, the importance of local knowledge, and the need for inclusive and equitable governance models. While the book occasionally lacks a clear articulation of viable alternatives, its call for decolonisation and inclusivity is a crucial contribution to the field.

Forests of Refuge challenges readers to reconsider the foundations of current conservation practices and to envision a future in which the voices of those most affected by environmental policies are heard and respected. Despite its theoretical density, the book's insights are crucial for advancing equitable and effective approaches to environmental conservation in postcolonial contexts. Undoubtedly, Collins' critique of the colonial underpinnings of environmental governance is both timely and necessary, offering valuable perspectives for scholars, policymakers, and activists alike. Decolonising environmental governance, like in the case of decolonising science, requires a commitment to sustained, equitable partnerships and the dismantling of entrenched power dynamics, which are the legacy of 500 years of history that goes beyond Indigenous land dispossession. Collins' work is a significant step in this direction, but it also calls on all of us to take concrete steps towards genuine decolonisation in our respective fields. How can we, as scholars and practitioners, move beyond merely critiquing existing frameworks to actively implementing decolonised practices? Collins' book challenges us to think deeply about this question and to consider our roles in fostering genuine and equitable partnerships. This book is essential for anyone interested in the intersection of environmental justice, decolonisation, and sustainable development.

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